

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

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The data for the present study are published online: [LINK]. We have no conflicts of interest to disclose. The present study was approved by the University of Iowa Institutional Review Board (Study #: INSERT). The authors complied with APA ethical standards in the treatment of participants. The study was funded by Grant HD098235 from the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Institutes of Health. Author roles were classified using the Contributor Role Taxonomy (CRediT; <https://credit.niso.org>) as follows: Isaac T. Petersen: conceptualization, data curation, analysis, funding, investigation, methodology, project administration, resources, software, supervision, validation, visualization, writing, editing; Zachary Demko: conceptualization, data curation, analysis, investigation, methodology, software, editing; Megan Schumer: editing

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Abstract

The field has not adequately studied individuals' development of psychopathology across the lifespan, instead taking a piecewise approach to development, limiting our understanding of lifespan development and the origins of psychopathology. We describe why this is the case—beyond logistical challenges. First, diagnostic and taxonomic systems do not define psychopathology constructs from a developmental perspective. A developmental perspective is crucial because psychopathology constructs often have earlier origins than their full clinical presentation, and forms of psychopathology frequently show changes in behavioral manifestation across development (heterotypic continuity). Second, current assessments do not adequately capture these changes in behavioral manifestation. Third, traditional scoring systems do not allow charting individuals' change over time in the face of changing behavioral manifestation. Fourth, assessments are not well-suited for capturing individual differences, despite the dimensional nature of psychopathology. We propose solutions to these challenges by introducing a developmental scaling framework for psychopathology. Using externalizing psychopathology as an example, we draw on our content analysis of externalizing measures, as well as lessons from the study of other constructs across lengthy developmental periods. Addressing these challenges will allow charting individuals' trajectories of psychopathology across the lifespan and identifying risk and protective factors that influence developmental courses.

Keywords: psychopathology, lifespan development, longitudinal trajectories, heterotypic continuity, externalizing behavior problems

Studying Development of Psychopathology Across the Lifespan

The Goal

The Problem/Obstacle

Reasons for the Problem

Solution

Other Key Challenges to Address

Conclusion

Appendix A

This Section Is an Appendix

Appendix B

Another Appendix